Daive A. Dunkley, *Women and Resistance in the Early Rastafari Movement*. Baton Rouge: Louisiana State University Press, 2021. xiv + 193 pp. (Cloth, US$ 45.00)

This is a politically timed text introducing a focus on women's voices and roots in early Rastafari through painstaking analysis of documents related to the circumstances surrounding the movement's genesis. The recovery and inscription of their contribution provides a treasure for the growing body of explication and research unfolding within the terrain of Rastafari Studies. And it arrives when Rastafari has been rebalancing the tradition to include the visibility and contributions of Empress Menen Asfaw and women in general in the Faith. Through a combination of text, archival search, and interviews, as well as a certain cultural grounding that indicates an appreciation for the guiding principles of the contemporary Rastafari worldview, Daive Dunkley has provided a window onto the emergence of the history and interior understanding of early Rastafari communities. Given that his priority is to illustrate the presence and active support, leadership, and overall contribution of women within Rastafari, the book extends the work begun by Charles Price's *Becoming Rasta* (2009), which also featured early Rastafari women's testimonies. More generally, *Women and Resistance in the Early Rastafari Movement* helps to anchor a womanist theoretical direction of Rastafari scholarship and activism that is usually associated with the latter decades of the culture's development.

The book, plotted in seven chapters, is a series of conversations about critical episodes in the history of the culture, women's agency, leadership, and foundational work in introducing and elaborating the mission, work, and experience of Rastafari within Jamaican society. It also highlights subtle and nuanced aspects of Rastafari that have not received much attention. Beyond the major theme of women's activism, the project provides a window on the texture of the social milieu in which these early devotees operated. Dunkley identifies a male bias in policing, media reportage, and overall engagement of women's presence and argues that it is a part of the patriarchal presumption of male dominance as well as imposing a type of censorship on the legitimate presence of women's foundational leadership work. He indicates that women inserted their voices in Leonard Howell's defense as witnesses and assisted with strategic matters related to the arguments brought before the courts at his trial. Howell's wife, Tenet Bent, is depicted as highly invested (in time, money, devotion, and love) for her husband and the people at Pinnacle, attending to issues of food, clothing, shelter, and education, especially for children, and maintaining the leadership of community while he was incarcerated. Dunkley also features Edna Fisher, the leading woman, whose congregation Claudius Henry joined, becoming its chief public image and police interest. He argues that despite the

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role played by such women, the justice system as well as the reporting media chose to mute or conceal their presence in the public sphere. These women are sketched as thoughtful and deliberate accomplices to the early congregations, helping to uphold the administration and build activities around a PanAfrican agenda for the community. Dunkley details women's organizing, and their navigation of both the movement and the traditional society, including dual membership in Rastafari and Kumina, Baptist, and Revival religions. He also debunks the myth of the Holy Herb as the purview of males, primarily by illustrating that women in the movement have always been involved with all aspects of the herb, and within the family were the chief harbingers of its prescription and administration, even to children, through tinctures and other preparations.

The book is nevertheless open to criticism for its unclear approaches to the representativeness of sample demographics, the selection of representatives, and the assumptions and general interpretations it advances in relation to gender and the early sociology of the movement. This tension is also epistemic in nature, and refers to resources available to researchers for retrieving the past, and how these are read, reread, and triangulated by way of contemporary lenses. Rastafari, and particularly Howell's prophetic tributary to it, is presented unproblematically as an established religion, even a *fait accompli* at the genesis of Howell's activism around 1934. Some scholars of this period make a distinction between Rastafari as a modern worldview and its first generation—a proto-Rastafari congregation of piety, inspiration, and livity, who largely focused on Howell and were thus usually identified as "Howellites." Some of these issues are mentioned only fleetingly in the penultimate chapter.

Overall, Dunkley has presented an important contribution to help anchor what has been described as the matriarchal shift, or the rise of the lioness, within the writing of Rastafari history. The book is a tribute to women such as Delrose Francis, Merriam Lennox, Tenet Bent, Edna Fisher, and Audrey Lewis, as well as other often overlooked cornerstones of Rastafari development.

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